

Scam TONES

Allegations of a Rs 60,000-crore scam in the issue of new licences and allocation of scarce spectrum raise questions of transparency and regulatory efficacy

| By Shankkar Aiyar |

In strife-torn Lebanon, they used to say anyone and everyone was shooting at anybody and everybody. You could say the same about the Telecom Ministry. Except this is not a civil war. The latest volley on what should be the reserve price for auctioning slots for 3G services is evolving into a controversy. Virtually an annual affair the ministry is enveloped in, allegations, counter-allegations and charges of scams—ranging from Rs 15,000 crore to Rs 60,000 crore depending on who is making them—are part of the landscape. MPs have written to the chief vigilance commissioner, questioning allotment of spectrum to existing players and to new licencees. Every acronym, from CVC to TRAI to TDSAT to PMO to CBI, is embedded in conversations.

But naturally, politicians sensing opportunity have jumped into the fray. CPI(M) MP Sitaram Yechury has written to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to “take immediate steps to scrap all licences and subsequent spectrum allotments”. Samajwadi Party General Secretary Amar Singh has alleged that telecom companies have offered him a bribe to silence him for raising the spectre of “a scam in allocation of extra spectrum to telecom companies”. He has demanded a CBI probe into the issue. AIADMK chief J. Jayalithaa has demanded that “Telecom and IT Minister A. Raja be sacked for causing loss to the



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